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Young And Old

There was one age-old issue that no training strategy was ever likely to fix. If the younger fighters were learning by studying their more decorated counterparts, then how would they ever learn to be *better* than them?

That was the question facing Dianna Dahlgren. Sure, she had youth on her side in a big way, but the edge went to teammate and mentor Catherine Bell everywhere else. Knowledge, experience, hardware... all things Cat had and Dianna wanted.

But... didn't she have them? With the exception of the hardware, hadn't she proven herself simply by reaching this final? After running over Hoopes and Bingham, there was no doubt that she had. But dealing with Cat was an entirely different story. This was a woman for whom she'd have no surprises. A woman who knew all her tricks because she was the one who'd taught them to her. And the older, wiser fighter had a message for her young pupil.

Sorry, young grasshopper, but it is not yet your time.

If there was any doubt about how this one was going to go, Cat quickly made things perfectly clear as she smushed her teammate into the canvas in less than three minutes.

Take that, ya' good for nothin' Millennial.

Despite the ribbing she's bound to take over it, the loss did little to dampen Dianna's excitement over her performance in this tournament. She'd done great things, and she had everyone talking about the even greater things to come.

I was right there with them in that excitement... but I've said this before, and I will, no doubt, have to say it again: Never sleep on Catherine Bell. In the past, I've called her *The Quiet Champion*, and that still rings true today. Her reserved demeanor and straight-ahead style make it easy for her to get lost in the noise, but I've never asked my fighters to put on a theatrical performance. I ask them for hard work and an honest effort every time they take to the cage. Mac has never let me down, and she's got a pretty impressive collection of hardware to show for it.

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Speaking of champions who fly under the radar, you never hear a whole lot from Daniela Hantuchova. Maybe it's the language barrier that holds her back. More likely, it's that she prefers to let her actions do the talking. And wow... did she ever have a lot to say in this one.

Daniela's final opponent was a bit of a surprise. Not that Amber Heard wasn't worthy, but no one gave her much of a chance of stopping the seemingly unbeatable Heidi Klum in the semi-final. Then fight night came and Heard emphatically proved all the doubters wrong... spending the first round methodically beating Klum stupid before dropping her less than forty seconds into the second. It was a stunning

performance that lead pundits to wonder if she could keep things rolling against Daniela. After all, they'd only met twice with each taking a victory. True, that had been years ago, but who's going to let a little thing like logic get in the way of a good storyline? As far as the league was concerned, this was going to be a fight for the ages. Daniela was a proven star. Amber was an excellent fighter, and she had just delivered a thumping to the woman ranked at the top of the weight class. Get your tickets now because this one's going to be war.

It turned out to be the shortest war in history.

That's not to say Amber wasn't good. Truth is, she managed more offense than all of Hantuchova's earlier round opponents combined. She even had the tennis star in trouble a few times. But Daniela has been there and seen it all, and she calmly reclaimed control each time while mounting a few assaults of her own. Then - just when it seemed the women were going to coast to the end of the round - Heard missed with an aggressive combo and gave Daniela all the opening she needed. A strong combo put Amber on her heels, and set her up for a brutal high kick that had her seeing stars. The Slovakian superstar immediately swarmed in to finish the job, and that was the end of that.

At this point, I really don't know what to say about Daniela that hasn't already been said. Her greatness is why we brought her here, and her overall performance since joining us has been nothing short of amazing. On top of that, she's been an outstanding mentor to Aly Michalka. It's an honor and a privilege to have a fighter with her talent in the RSI fold.

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While the league may have overreached a bit in the effort to promote the fight between Amber and Daniela, the showdown between Torrie Wilson and Maria Sharapova basically advertised itself. Sharapova, who'd been a factor in the title picture for nearly half a decade, had now presided over the ESL super heavyweight division for over two years straight. Tournaments, special events... if there's a title Maria's eligible to win, then her name will be first on the list of likely candidates. She's faced the best and beaten them all.

Well... all except for one.

I'm not going to sugarcoat things... Torrie was basically a wreck when she came to RSI. At the time, she was coming off her thirtieth fight... a victory that brought her win total to a whopping ten. Was she really that terrible? No. In fact, she managed to put up a solid fight just about every time she stepped in the cage. But putting on a good show doesn't really count for much, and a veteran fighter who only wins a third of her fights is very likely to find herself pursuing a different career path in short order. Such was the case for Wilson, who was released by her stable a week after the event... at a time when freelance fighters were quickly becoming a rarity in the league. Add in the age factor, and... well, Torrie needed a miracle, and she needed it fast.

Enter Stephanie McMahon.

We needed competition. Someone who could train with Steph and help push our struggling super heavyweight back to the top of the rankings. Trouble was, every available fighter who fit the bill was also one of Steph's direct competitors. She didn't want that, and, quite frankly, neither did I.

As the discussion wore on, it was Steph who threw Torrie's name out there.

I remember thinking, *Huh?* then checking the divisional rankings for Torrie's name... where I found her listed dead last. A veteran fighter, ranked at the absolute bottom. Even behind the rookies.

Steph said the numbers were wrong. That Torrie was more than what she seemed.

I said the numbers weren't complicated. They were wins and losses... and when you added Torrie's up, the sum was god-awful.

Steph asked me to trust her, and really... how could I argue? All the balls were in her court. She knew Torrie better than I did. As Development Coordinator, she would be the one charged with getting Wilson on the right track. And if it all went to hell, she would be the one lacking a training partner.

So I just shrugged... and it was the greatest shrug I ever gave.

The turnaround started immediately. Boom, boom, boom. Torrie rattled off three wins in a row. A fluky loss, then another pair of wins.

Then came the tournament that changed everything. Two years ago at this same event, in fact. The basic nature of the tournament format is simple. When you good, you get a high seed, and you usually don't have to worry about facing the best of the best until the late rounds. When you suck, you get thrown straight into the fire. Despite her brief run of success, Wilson came in seeded twenty-fifth. That wasn't good, so it must have been the other one. She faced an uphill battle from square one, and her hopes of actually winning the title were practically zero.

She did it anyway, beating a trio of top ten fighters along the way. She set the tone early with a swift and absolute victory over nine seed Jennifer Ellison. The second round brought her a reprieve of sorts in the similarly-seeded Mariah Carey. Torrie turned it into a statement, winning by knockout in less than three minutes.

Then came round three, where Ms. Wilson was faced with every fighter's nightmare. Being next up to get mowed down by the top seed. Only Torrie didn't wilt under the pressure. In fact, she didn't even flinch. Instead, she stood tall, fought smart and came out the victor in a violent fight that lasted nearly two full rounds.

Her victim? The one and only Maria Sharapova.

The win sent the assembled media into spasms. Though we at RSI had been paying close attention to the little signs that suggested Torrie was on the upswing, the rest of the world saw a washed up fighter swoop in out of nowhere and upend one of the league's premier stars.

The frenzy got so out of control, it was almost as if the rest of the tournament didn't matter. Like Torrie had already won the whole damn thing. But what followed turned out to be important - especially for Rampage Sports. After ending a Cinderella run by Gabrielle Richens in round four, the title bout brought Torrie her third top ten opponent... which came in the form of the sixth-seeded Stephanie McMahon.

The stage was set for a storybook ending. While Torrie had emerged from obscurity to shock the world, Steph had spent the tournament putting on a show of her own... beating eleven seed Melissa Debling, three seed Uma Thurman and two seed Gemma Atkinson in quick succession. Clearly, Torrie had not been the only one benefiting from her presence at RSI, and the possibilities had me giddy. No matter the outcome of the final, it looked like Rampage Sports was going to come out with two world-class athletes, ready to take on all comers.

The reality? Well... we don't talk much about what happened in that fight anymore because that's where the storybook turned into a horror story. It ended with our new, first-time champion sobbing in the cage as she knelt beside her fallen - and badly broken - mentor.

It was just one of those things that make you shake your head while you look for a rock to kick. Steph had already suffered enough injuries and setbacks in her career. Then - just as she seemed poised to make the final push back to the top - another injury had her back on the shelf. What it did to her... well, that's a story for another day.

As for Torrie, the dark moment threatened to overshadow what should have been the well-earned highlight of her difficult career. But we weren't going to let that happen. Both Danni and I were front and center at her press conference, ready to steer the questions away from the negative. Steph got her broken ribs wrapped up and made an appearance as well. What happened had cost her dearly. She wasn't going to let Torrie pay the price, too.

In the end, the narrative came out the way it should have. Torrie Wilson had turned the corner, and she wasn't looking back. What happened in the months that followed cemented that as fact. Rising from the twenty-fifth slot to capture the title will earn you a lot of fans, and Torrie had no trouble hanging on to them as the wins kept coming. So did the titles. First another tournament crown, then the coveted divisional belt. In the span of eighteen months, she'd gone from the literal bottom to the very top. The words *media darling* don't even begin to cover her current status.

Which brings us back to the promotion for tonight's fight. The woman who was probably the greatest comeback story the league had ever seen up against one of it's most prestigious champions? Nobody had to do any work to sell that. In fact, they almost needed to dial it down for fear that expectations would reach a level Torrie and Maria could never meet.

In the end, they didn't even come close.

Chance will always be part of sports. There is no way to remove it. In fight sports - where hurting your opponent is the actual goal - the most unpredictable element is injuries. There are so many things happening at once. Sudden, violent and often unorthodox attacks are a constant. It feels like a freak injury

could happen at any second, and one of those seconds hit just as the first round was drawing to a close. It was - to put it mildly - a damn shame. The early battle had been entertaining and well-fought round from both sides, and it offered strong hints that something epic was brewing.

Then Torrie threw an innocent-looking, purely defensive jab that didn't even land... and that was the end of everything.

Right away, it was clear that something was very wrong. A look of intense pain suddenly took over Torrie's face. Like any fighter worth her salt, she masked it immediately. I can tell you this is an automatic response.

Your brain sends a message: *Hey! Something really bad just happened.*

Then the fighter mentality takes over: *OK, we've got an emergency. Gotta get control of it. Get the defense in place. Make adjustments. Figure out how to survive to the break.*

Just as Torrie set her guard and got ready to turtle up, the clacker sounded at cageside.

Only ten seconds to go, she no doubt told herself. A lucky break.

Break? Yes.

Lucky? No.

Referee Rebecca Loos spotted the problem immediately and paused the fight without a moment's hesitation. The medical team was summoned, but that was nothing more than a formality. Everyone with eyes knew the fight was over... because Torrie's right pinkie was very obviously sticking out at an angle nearly ninety degrees away from the rest of her hand.

How it happened was never clear. Replay footage showed the jab landing on Sharapova's guard, but it offered no clue as to how such an innocuous exchange resulted in such a gruesome injury. Regardless, there was no choice in the matter. The cageside doctor had to stop the fight.

It was a tough way to lose, especially when both fighters were fighting so well. The fans were disappointed, of course, and they were far from alone. Maria made a point of stopping over to chat with Torrie before the official announcement, and you can bet she was not only offering condolences on the bad luck but also lamenting what might have been.

Meanwhile, the RSI scorecard was looking decent, but not great. Two wins in five tries is something I would ordinarily be pretty happy with, but that wasn't going to get it done here. Not when we were all anyone could talk about.

The good news? We had three of our very best still to come.

The bad news? The league didn't save these fights for the end because they thought they'd be predictable. Having our best in the cage was a plus, but they would be in there with the best the rest of the league had to offer. The stats showed no real edge for anyone, and any little thing could be the difference.

In other words, this wasn't gonna be no picnic.